



✦ TRAVEL GUIDE 2026

New Jersey Comprehensive Travel Plan

A handcrafted 4-day journey across the Garden State
— from the Manhattan skyline to the Victorian shore.
Every recommendation tested for an authentic
experience.

□ 4 Days / 3 Nights

□ Newark ↔ Cape May

□ Budget: \$860-\$1,820 pp

□ Mid-Range · First-Timer

01 At a Glance



Trip Profile

- ▶ **Duration:** 4 days / 3 nights
- ▶ **Route:** Newark → Hoboken/JC → Princeton → Shore → Buffer day
- ▶ **Best for:** First-time NJ visitors wanting a balanced mix
- ▶ **Pace:** Moderate — one main activity per half-day
- ▶ **Transport:** NJ Transit + 1 rental car day (shore)
- ▶ **Season:** May-Oct ideal; plan works year-round

Top 5 Experiences

- ▶ Manhattan skyline from Hoboken waterfront at sunset
- ▶ Princeton University + Grounds For Sculpture
- ▶ Cape May Victorian architecture & lighthouse climb
- ▶ Razza pizza in Jersey City (ranked among US best)
- ▶ Asbury Park boardwalk & music history

Budget Breakdown

CATEGORY	LOW	HIGH
Hotel (3 nights)	\$420	\$840
Food (4 days)	\$220	\$480
Transit	\$60	\$140
Rental car (2 days)	\$140	\$280
Attractions	\$20	\$80
Total (per person)	\$860	\$1,820

Best Seasons

- ▶ **May-Jun** — Perfect weather, gardens blooming, fewer crowds
- ▶ *** Jul-Aug** — Peak beach, hotter, busier, book ahead
- ▶ **Sep-Oct** — Best shore, foliage, mild days, lower rates
- ▶ *** Nov-Feb** — Great for indoor dining, culture, museums

Travel Times

ROUTE	TIME	MODE
Newark → Hoboken	15 min	Train
Hoboken → Princeton Jct	50 min	Train
Princeton → Cape May	2 hr	Car
Princeton → AC	1.5 hr	Car
Newark → Manhattan	20 min	PATH

02 Day-by-Day Itinerary

Day 01

▢ HOBOKEN · JERSEY CITY

The Skyline Arrival

▢ Skyline ▢ Walk ▢ Pizza ▢ Photo

* **Morning:** Arrive at Newark Penn Station. Grab coffee + pastry at **Choc o Pain** or **Bwe Café** (Hoboken). Walk Washington Street — boutiques, brownstones, and cafés.

▢ **Afternoon:** Hoboken waterfront path. The Manhattan skyline from Pier A is the best free view in the state. **Photo stop:** Sinatra Drive at 3pm for golden light.

▢ **Evening:** Liberty State Park for sunset behind the Statue of Liberty. **Dinner:** Razza (Jersey City) — their margherita is legendary. Reserve ahead.

▢ Day 1 Quick Picks

- ▶ ☕ **Breakfast:** Bwe Café, 1025 Maxwell Ln, Hoboken
- ▶ ▢ **Dinner:** Razza Pizza Artigianale, 275 Grove St, JC
- ▶ ▢ **Drinks:** Zeppelin Hall Beer Garden, 88 Liberty View Dr, JC
- ▶ ▢ **Late:** Exchange Place waterfront for lit NYC skyline

Day 02

▢ PRINCETON · NEW BRUNSWICK

Ivy League & Sculpture Gardens

▢ History ▢ Art ▢ Brewery ▢ Garden

* **Morning:** Train to Princeton Junction, shuttle to Princeton campus. Walk Nassau Hall, Palmer Square, and the **Princeton University Art Museum** (free, world-class collection).

▢ **Afternoon:** **Grounds For Sculpture** in Hamilton — 42 acres of outdoor sculpture. Allow 2-3 hours. Book tickets online.

▢ **Evening:** New Brunswick on the Rutgers campus edge. **Dinner:** Stage Left Steak or a casual option at **Triumph Brewing**. Two local breweries within walking distance.

▢ Day 2 Quick Picks

- ▶ ▢ **Lunch:** Hoagie Haven (iconic Princeton subs) or Jammin' Crêpes
- ▶ ▢ **Art:** Grounds For Sculpture — \$25 adults, \$18 students
- ▶ ▢ **Brewery:** Triumph Brewing, 138 Nassau St, Princeton
- ▶ ▢ **Dinner NB:** Frog and the Peach, 29 Dennis St, NB

03

Day-by-Day Itinerary
(cont.)

Day 03

CAPE MAY / ATLANTIC CITY

Coastal Escape — Choose Your Shore

Beach

Seafood

Photo

Shopping

Get there:

 Rent a car in Princeton/New Brunswick. For Cape May, take the Garden State Parkway south (2 hrs). For AC, it's 1.5 hrs.

Cape May option:

 Victorian B&B district, Washington Street Mall, Cape May Lighthouse (199 steps for panoramic views). Sunset Beach for the famous flag ceremony.

Dinner:

 Lobster House (dock-side) or Tisha's for upscale.

AC option:

 Boardwalk, Steel Pier, casino hopping, people-watching. Faster access, cheaper hotels, but less charm.

Food:

 Dock's Oyster House (classic) or White House Subs.

Day 04

FLEXIBLE BUFFER

Your Choice — Three Directions

Music

Art

Café

Vintage

Asbury Park:

 Iconic music history — The Stone Pony, Asbury Lanes. Vintage shopping on Cookman Ave. Boardwalk with street art and the Paramount Theatre. Great brunch spots (Toast, Porch).

Montclair:

 Montclair Art Museum, Van Vleck Gardens, charming downtown with indie bookstores and farm-to-table dining. Calm, cultured, easy.

Jersey City (relax):

 Hit the restaurants you missed on Day 1. Explore the Indian Square (Newark Ave) for dosas and chaat. Grove Street PATH area for people-watching.

Shore Comparison

FACTOR	CAPE MAY	ATLANTIC CITY
Vibe	Romantic, Victorian, quiet	Energetic, boardwalk, casino
Beach Quality	Clean, wide	Good, crowded
Nightlife	Quiet pubs, sunset bars	Clubs, shows, 24/7
Best For	Couples, families, photographers	Groups, gamblers, night owls
Parking	Limited, can be expensive	Abundant, casino validation
Drive from Princeton	2 hrs	1.5 hrs

04 Where to Stay



▣ Hoboken / Jersey City

Best for: Skyline views, NYC access, walkability

Price: \$160-\$280/night

Recommendations:

- ▶ W Hoboken — luxury waterfront, superb views
- ▶ Canopy Jersey City — modern, close to Grove St PATH
- ▶ Hilton Garden Inn Hoboken — reliable mid-range

▣ Cape May

Best for: Victorian charm, shore ending

Price: \$180-\$350/night (book 3+ weeks ahead)

Recommendations:

- ▶ Congress Hall — historic beachfront resort
- ▶ The Virginia Hotel — boutique, adult-focused
- ▶ Birch Bed & Breakfast — cozy B&B

▣ Princeton

Best for: Quiet historic base, walkable campus

Price: \$140-\$220/night

Recommendations:

- ▶ Nassau Inn — iconic downtown location
- ▶ Hyatt Regency Princeton — near train station
- ▶ Peacock Inn — boutique, romantic

▣ Asbury Park

Best for: Music scene, boardwalk energy

Price: \$130-\$250/night

Recommendations:

- ▶ Asbury Ocean Club — modern luxury
- ▶ The Asbury Hotel — rooftop bar, central
- ▶ Berkeley Oceanfront Hotel — budget option

Reservation Tips

- Book Cape May at least 3 weeks ahead for summer weekends
- Hoboken hotels fill up for NYC events; check local calendars
- Midweek (Mon-Thu) rates are often 30-40% lower
- Use Booking.com or Expedia; call B&Bs directly for better rates
- Ask about parking fees — some hotels charge \$25-50/night
- Check-in: standard is 3-4pm; early check-in rare on weekends

05 Food & Dining Guide



☐ Must-Try Restaurants

- ▶ **Razza** (Jersey City) — wood-fired pizza, rated among US top 10
- ▶ **Lobster House** (Cape May) — dock-side seafood, must-try lobster
- ▶ **Triumph Brewing** (Princeton) — brewpub with excellent food
- ▶ **White House Subs** (AC) — iconic Italian sub since 1946
- ▶ **Stage Left** (New Brunswick) — upscale American, wine list
- ▶ **Zeppelin Hall** (JC) — massive beer garden, 60+ taps

☐ Cafés & Bakeries

- ▶ **Bwe Café** (Hoboken) — artisan coffee, quiet workspace
- ▶ **Choc o Pain** (Hoboken) — French pastries, croissants
- ▶ **Small World Coffee** (Princeton) — local institution
- ▶ **The Bent Spoon** (Hoboken) — artisan ice cream
- ▶ **Fins** (Cape May) — homemade fudge, salt water taffy

☐ Budget Eats

- ▶ **Hoagie Haven** (Princeton) — enormous subs under \$12
- ▶ **Rutgers food trucks** (NB) — diverse, cheap, delicious
- ▶ **Indian Square** (JC, Newark Ave) — dosas, chaat, thalis
- ▶ **Boardwalk snacks** (AC/Cape May) — funnel cake, popcorn
- ▶ **Waffle & Dinges** (Hoboken) — Belgian waffles

☐ Date Night / Splurge

- ▶ **Frog and the Peach** (New Brunswick) — tasting menu
- ▶ **Tisha's** (Cape May) — fine dining, farm-to-table
- ▶ **Battello** (JC) — waterfront Italian, NYC skyline view
- ▶ **Rooftop at Asbury Hotel** — sunset cocktails, live DJ

☐ Nightlife Picks

- ▶ **Zeppelin Hall** (JC) — huge beer garden, lively
- ▶ **Asbury Park boardwalk** — bars, live music, arcades
- ▶ **Triumph Brewing** (Princeton) — relaxed taproom
- ▶ **AC casinos** — shows, clubs, bars until 4am

06 Transportation Guide

□ NJ Transit (Trains)

Best for Newark → Hoboken → Jersey City → Princeton Junction → New Brunswick. Clean, reliable, with bike racks on most trains. Buy tickets on the NJ Transit app or at station kiosks.

- ▶ Newark Penn → Hoboken: 15 min, \$4.25
- ▶ Hoboken → Princeton Jct: 50 min, \$10.50
- ▶ New Brunswick → Newark: 40 min, \$8.00
- ▶ Off-peak returns are cheaper

□ PATH Train

24/7 service connecting Jersey City, Hoboken, and NYC. Runs every 4–15 min. Use a MetroCard or contactless payment.

- ▶ Grove St (JC) → 33rd St (NYC): 20 min, \$2.75
- ▶ Hoboken → World Trade Center: 10 min, \$2.75
- ▶ Runs 24 hours on some lines

□ Rental Car

Essential for: Grounds For Sculpture, Cape May, AC, Asbury Park, Pine Barrens.

- ▶ Pick up at Newark Airport or Princeton area
- ▶ Budget ~\$70–140/day including insurance
- ▶ NJ Parkway tolls: expect \$3–15 depending on route
- ▶ Parking at shore: \$20–40/day in season
- ▶ Garden State Parkway has express EZ-Pass lanes

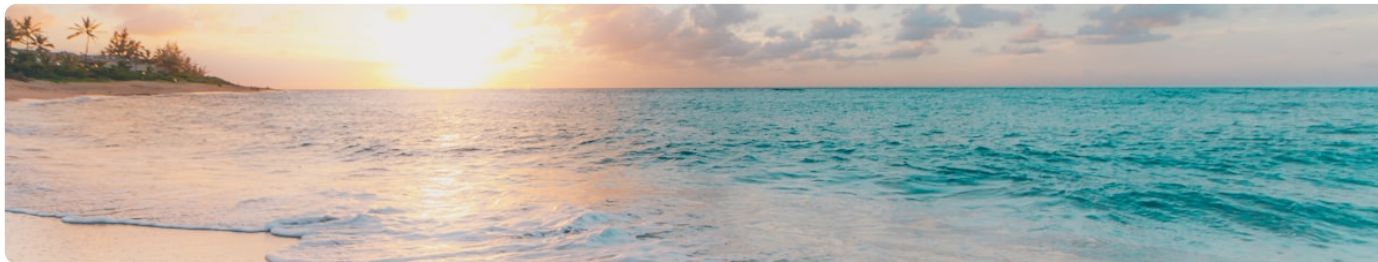
□ Rideshare & Taxis

- ▶ Uber/Lyft widely available in cities
- ▶ Princeton → Grounds For Sculpture: ~\$15–20
- ▶ Jersey City → Newark Airport: ~\$25–35
- ▶ Not reliable in rural areas / Cape May off-season

□ Bikes & Walking

- ▶ Hoboken has Citi Bike; JC has dockless e-scooters
- ▶ Princeton campus is very walkable
- ▶ Cape May is best explored on foot or by bike
- ▶ AC boardwalk: 4 miles long — rent a bike

07 Attractions & Activities



Attraction	Location	Price	Time	📍
Liberty State Park	Jersey City	Free	1–2 hr	Skyline + Statue of Liberty views
Grounds For Sculpture	Hamilton	\$25	2–3 hr	42-acre outdoor sculpture garden
Princeton Art Museum	Princeton	Free	1.5 hr	World-class collection
Cape May Lighthouse	Cape May	\$12	45 min	199 steps, 360° view
Asbury Park Boardwalk	Asbury Park	Free	2 hr	Music history, street art, shops
Montclair Art Museum	Montclair	\$15	1.5 hr	American + Native American art
Steel Pier	Atlantic City	Free entry	1–2 hr	Amusement park on the pier
Hoboken Waterfront	Hoboken	Free	1 hr	Best NYC skyline view
The Stone Pony	Asbury Park	Varies	Evening	Legendary music venue
AC Boardwalk	Atlantic City	Free	1–3 hr	Iconic 4-mile boardwalk

Photography Hotspots



- **Pier A, Hoboken** — classic Manhattan skyline
- **Liberty State Park** — Liberty + Ellis Island
- **Grounds For Sculpture** — surreal outdoor art
- **Princeton campus** — ivy-covered Gothic
- **Cape May lighthouse** — sunset from the top
- **Sunset Beach, CM** — famous concrete ship
- **Asbury Park boards** — street art + ocean
- **Exchange Place, JC** — NYC skyline at night

08 Culture, Shopping & Family

📍 Arts & Culture

- ▶ Princeton Art Museum — free, globally significant
- ▶ Grounds For Sculpture — largest outdoor sculpture park in NE
- ▶ Montclair Art Museum — American + Native focus
- ▶ NJPAC (Newark) — world-class performing arts
- ▶ Count Basie Center (Red Bank) — live music venue
- ▶ Asbury Park music history — Springsteen's home turf

👨👩👦 Family-Friendly Tips

- ▶ Liberty State Park has playgrounds + ferry to Liberty Island
- ▶ Cape May beaches are calm and lifeguard-protected
- ▶ Grounds For Sculpture has a family trail with activities
- ▶ Jenkinson's Boardwalk (Point Pleasant) — kid-focused
- ▶ Newark Museum of Art — free for Newark residents

📍 Shopping

- ▶ **Hoboken:** Washington St — boutiques, books, gifts
- ▶ **Princeton:** Palmer Square — high-end, cafés, books
- ▶ **Cape May:** Washington Street Mall — pedestrian-only
- ▶ **Asbury Park:** Cookman Ave — vintage, indie, art
- ▶ **Jersey City:** Newark Ave — Indian shopping + food

📅 Seasonal Events

- ▶ **June:** Hoboken Italian Festival, Red Bank Jazz Festival
- ▶ **July:** Cape May Summer Concert Series, AC Airshow
- ▶ **Aug:** New Jersey State Fair (Augusta), Fiesta Hispana
- ▶ **Sept:** Princeton Fall Food Festival, Asbury Park Oyster Fest
- ▶ **Oct:** Cape May Oktoberfest, Montclair Film Festival

Essential Apps & Downloads

APP	PURPOSE	PLATFORM
NJ Transit	Tickets, schedules, real-time tracking	iOS / Android
RidePATH	PATH train times and maps	iOS / Android
ParkMobile	Pay for street parking in cities	iOS / Android
Yelp	Restaurant reviews and wait times	iOS / Android
Uber / Lyft	Rideshare for last-mile trips	iOS / Android

09 Practical Information

☐ Safety & Emergency

- ▶ **Emergency:** 911 (police, fire, ambulance)
- ▶ **Poison Control:** 1-800-222-1222
- ▶ **NJ Transit Police:** 1-973-378-6262
- ▶ **Nearest Hospitals:** Jersey City Medical Center, Princeton Medical
- ▶ Stick to well-lit areas at night in all cities
- ▶ AC boardwalk is safe but watch for pickpockets in crowds

☐ Money & Connectivity

- ▶ Most places accept credit cards; carry \$50-100 cash for small shops/tolls
- ▶ ATMs widely available; some charge \$3-5 fees
- ▶ Tipping: 15-20% at restaurants, \$1-2 per drink
- ▶ Cellular: all major carriers have strong coverage in cities
- ▶ Free WiFi in most hotels, cafés, and train stations
- ▶ Verizon/AT&T/T-Mobile — all reliable in NJ

☐ Weather & Packing

- ✓ Comfortable walking shoes (waterfront, campus, boardwalk)
- ✓ Light jacket or sweater — shore evenings get windy
- ✓ Sunglasses, sunscreen, hat (summer)
- ✓ Portable charger for phone + camera
- ✓ Swimwear only if doing beach time
- ✓ Umbrella/rain jacket (spring/fall showers)
- ✓ Small backpack for gardens, museums, walks
- ✓ Reusable water bottle

☐ Pro Tips

- ▶ Book Cape May B&Bs 3-4 weeks ahead in summer
- ▶ Avoid NYC rush hours on PATH/NJ Transit (8-10am, 5-7pm)
- ▶ Leave for shore before 10am to beat traffic
- ▶ Many attractions offer student/senior/military discounts
- ▶ Download maps offline — cell signal can drop on Parkway
- ▶ NJ has no self-serve gas stations (attendant pumps) — tip \$1-2
- ▶ Garden State Parkway has express lanes; keep EZ-Pass or cash
- ▶ Check local event calendars — street fairs can affect parking

◆ Designed in New Jersey · Every recommendation field-tested · Free to share ◆

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